costs. This message created some agitation in the Corps HQ for it implied that the Chinese had crossed their 1960 claim line and had cut off the axis between Tr Jn and DBO.

Bikram Singh discussed the matter with Raina who suggested both DBO and Tr Jn be abandoned and the troops pulled back to Sasar Brangza. The corps commander then spoke to Daulet Singh who confirmed the order subject to Randhawa's discretion. Late in the evening on 22 October, the order to withdraw if required was passed to all concerned. At the same time, the army commander also gave orders to fly additional mortars, mines, jeeps and ammunition to Tr Jn.

As it turned out, quite a few posts had held out; most of them would break contact only later that night. The Chinese, on the other hand, having succeeded in clearing the Indians from the heights, never assaulted or occupied DBO or Tr Jn. On 23 October, after burning the five trucks and four jeeps and destroying the fuel dump, the rest of the troops at DBO fell back with the Jats to Murgo. (They would subsequently get to Thoise from where Charlie Company of 5 Jat was flown to Chushul to link up with the rest of the battalion.)

Seventy men of 14 J&K Militia were lost in the fighting. Those who were at DBO withdrew with the Jats, but Major Randhawa's group from Tr Jn chose to follow the Chip Chap–Shyok River route. Once they entered the glaciated region, they lost complete contact with Battalion HQ but were fortunately spotted by a reconnaissance aircraft a day later. The column reached Sasar Brangza safely, with Randhawa having also withdrawn his other troops from Burtse, Sultan Chushku and the Galwan–Shyok River junction.

The Qara Qash sector was perhaps the remotest part in what was already the back of beyond. This plateau, with the lowest point of 15,400 feet and the surrounding features all in excess of 20,000 feet, was the area where the Murgo Chu, Qara Qash, Galwan and Nachhu Chu originated; all the river valleys were above 16,000 feet. There were two camps in this sector—Sumdo and Sultan Chushku. Not only was the sector geographically forbidding, with the main Karakoram Range passing through it, most explorers in the past had given it wide berth. The Survey of India (and the Kashmir State) records were scanty and most features were not marked accurately.